



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

A NEW CIVILISATIONAL PARADIGM

It is significant that both Bhagwat and his deputy Hosabale talk of a new civilisational paradigm. The RSS has always held that an Indian nation without its cultural moorings would be like a boat adrift in troubled seas. Hence, the advocacy of Hindutva defined as a revival of India's Hindu identity based on the inclusivity of its spiritual traditions and its wealth of value systems. It is meant to be a Dharmic transformation and not a narrow religious denomination. The genesis of the Mandir agitation lay in trying to get rid of the main symbols of what was perceived as India's subjugation and cultural repression by both Muslim invaders and Christian colonisers for a thousand years. The erstwhile Babri Masjid in Ayodhya, the Gyanvapi mosque in Varanasi and the Idgah mosque in Mathura were seen as prime examples of how Hindu temples had been destroyed and converted into Muslims places of worship. Nehru's secularism was seen as appeasement of minority communities and a suppression of the true life force that had made India great in the past. Sunil Ambekar, Akhil Bharatiya Prachar Pramukh of the RSS, terms it as *smriti bhramit* existence (a phase of history marked by a distorted or misplaced memory of a nation's culture and values) and says, "We all had suffered from a collective amnesia. Now, there is a cultural awakening. Our main *tatva* (principle) is unity within, and how we connect with our cultural ties. For the consecration, the entire nation has come together, irrespective of caste, creed, community and economic disparity. Though ancient, it has become a symbol of modern times—the Ram temple movement has become one of the major connecting points of our culture."

THE BJP-RSS ARE DETERMINED THAT THEY WILL RELY ON DUE PROCESS OF LAW TO SETTLE DISPUTES IN OTHER PLACES SUCH AS KASHI AND MATHURA AND NOT SUPPORT AGITATIONS

Apart from the Ram Mandir, there were two other major instruments that the RSS saw as essential for the cultural revitalisation of the country: the abrogation of Article 370 that gave Jammu and Kashmir, India's only Muslim-majority state, an autonomous status, and the need for a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) that will not discriminate on the basis of caste or creed. To Modi's credit, in his second term, he has been able to fulfil two of the RSS's three major objectives—the construction of the Ram Mandir at Ayodhya and the abrogation of Article 370 in 2019. By passing the Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Marriage) Act, 2019, which bans the practice of triple talaq, Modi has made a significant move towards establishing a UCC. It also saw him win the support of Muslim women. All these three RSS goals had been achieved using legal means and cleared by no less than the

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